

## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# Indo-Pacific, Indian Ocean and Maritime Security - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

| Indo-Pacific, Indian Ocean and Maritime Security |                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST |                                                                                                                                                            |
| 01                                               | <b>FOUNDATION — WHAT THE MARITIME OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE</b><br>Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated     |
| 02                                               | <b>FOUNDATION — SEA-LANE DEPENDENCE AND THE MALACCA CHOKEPOINT</b><br>Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the                   |
| 03                                               | <b>FOUNDATION — SAGAR AND ITS MAHASAGAR EXTENSION</b><br>MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating                                   |
| 04                                               | <b>CORE — THE CONVENTION FRAMEWORK AND INDIA'S USE OF ITS DISPUTE MACHINERY</b><br>India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on     |
| 05                                               | <b>CORE — THE BBNJ AGREEMENT AND THE SIGNATURE-RATIFICATION GAP</b><br>Evidence chain: The BBNJ Agreement and the signature-ratification                   |
| 06                                               | <b>CORE — IORA AND IONS: CHAIRSHIP AGAINST CONTROL</b><br>Evidence chain: IORA and the difference between a chairship and                                  |
| 07                                               | <b>CORE — THE INFORMATION FUSION CENTRE AND INDIA'S OWN NAVAL INSTRUMENTS</b><br>Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at          |
| 08                                               | <b>CORE — THE INDIA-MALDIVES JOINT VISION AS THE ISLAND-STATE INSTRUMENT</b><br>Evidence chain: The India-Maldives Joint Vision as the island-state        |
| 09                                               | <b>CORE — COLOMBO SECURITY CONCLAVE PARTICIPATION CATEGORIES</b><br>Evidence chain: Colombo Security Conclave participation categories                     |
| 10                                               | <b>CORE — THE INDO-PACIFIC OCEANS INITIATIVE AND ASEAN CENTRALITY</b><br>India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth              |
| 11                                               | <b>CORE — EXERCISE MALABAR AND THE ASYMMETRY INSIDE THE QUADRILATERAL</b><br>Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the             |
| 12                                               | <b>CORE — AUKUS, THE SUBMARINE PATHWAY AND THE SAFEGUARDS QUESTION</b><br>Evidence chain: AUKUS, the submarine pathway and the safeguards                  |
| 13                                               | <b>CORE SYNTHESIS — DEFENCE ENABLERS AND THE SIMULTANEOUS RUSSIAN CAPABILITY BASE</b><br>The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics |
| 14                                               | <b>CORE SYNTHESIS — THE INTERNATIONAL MARITIME ORGANIZATION AS THE SECTORAL</b><br>Evidence chain: The International Maritime Organization and India's     |
| 15                                               | <b>CORE SYNTHESIS — EXTERNAL-POWER BASING, ISLAND-STATE AGENCY AND HONEST</b><br>Evidence chain: External-power basing, island-state agency and            |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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# Indo-Pacific, Indian Ocean and Maritime Security - Solved Practice Workbook

## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

**Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this maritime owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. C. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.

**Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

## Q2. Which card should be filed under What this maritime owner holds and how its boundaries are routed in an International Relations answer?

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. B. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. C. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. D. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.

**Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

## Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this maritime owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot



vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. D. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.

**Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this maritime owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?**

A. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. D. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian



energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners.

**Answer: D. Explanation:** This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q5. Which statement correctly identifies Sea-lane dependence and the Malacca chokepoint as the baseline interest?**

A. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. C. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. D. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine.

**Answer: A. Explanation:** Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q6. Which card should be filed under Sea-lane dependence and the Malacca chokepoint as the baseline interest in an International Relations answer?**

A. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. B. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. C. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. D. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine.

**Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sea-lane dependence and the Malacca chokepoint as the baseline interest?**

A. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. D. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's

maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sea-lane dependence and the Malacca chokepoint as the baseline interest?**

A. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q9. Which statement correctly identifies SAGAR as a declared vision and not a treaty?**

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as

signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. D. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.

**Answer: A. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q10. Which card should be filed under SAGAR as a declared vision and not a treaty in an International Relations answer?**

A. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. C. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. D. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation.

**Answer: B. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



**Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of SAGAR as a declared vision and not a treaty?**

A. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. B. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic.

**Answer: C. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about SAGAR as a declared vision and not a treaty?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. C. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal

instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.

**Answer: D. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q13. Which statement correctly identifies MAHASAGAR as extension of scope and not replacement?**

A. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. B. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. C. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. D. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation.

**Answer: A. Explanation: MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q14. Which card should be filed under MAHASAGAR as extension of scope and not replacement in an International Relations answer?**

A. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. B. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for

development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic.

**Answer: B. Explanation: MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of MAHASAGAR as extension of scope and not replacement?**

A. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. B. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. C. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. D. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility.

**Answer: C. Explanation: MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider**



**Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about MAHASAGAR as extension of scope and not replacement?**

A. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. B. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. C. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. D. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine.

**Answer: D. Explanation: MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q17. Which statement correctly identifies India's UNCLOS position and its domestic maritime-zones law?**

A. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. B. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for

one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation.

**Answer: A. Explanation: India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q18. Which card should be filed under India's UNCLOS position and its domestic maritime-zones law in an International Relations answer?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic.

**Answer: B. Explanation: India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of India's UNCLOS position and its domestic maritime-zones law?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. C. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. D. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility.

**Answer: C. Explanation: India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about India's UNCLOS position and its domestic maritime-zones law?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. C. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy

channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. D. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.

**Answer: D. Explanation: India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q21. Which statement correctly identifies The BBNJ Agreement and the signature-ratification gap?**

A. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. B. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. C. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. D. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



**Q22. Which card should be filed under The BBNJ Agreement and the signature-ratification gap in an International Relations answer?**

A. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. B. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The BBNJ Agreement and the signature-ratification gap?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. C. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification



as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. D. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The BBNJ Agreement and the signature-ratification gap?**

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. B. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. C. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. D. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. The remaining options belong to different actors,**

**Q25. Which statement correctly identifies IORA and the difference between a chairship and control?**

A. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. B. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. C. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. D. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q26. Which card should be filed under IORA and the difference between a chairship and control in an International Relations answer?**

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. B. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. C. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral

anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. D. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of IORA and the difference between a chairship and control?**

A. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. B. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. C. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about IORA and the difference between a chairship and control?**

A. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. C. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. D. The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q29. Which statement correctly identifies IONS as a voluntary naval-cooperation symposium?**

A. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. B. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with



the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. D. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q30. Which card should be filed under IONS as a voluntary naval-cooperation symposium in an International Relations answer?**

A. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. B. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. C. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



### Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of IONS as a voluntary naval-cooperation symposium?

A. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. B. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. C. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about IONS as a voluntary naval-cooperation symposium?

A. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. B. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. C. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association

of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. D. The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q33. Which statement correctly identifies IFC-IOR as the operational maritime-domain-awareness layer?**

A. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. B. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. D. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. The remaining options belong to different**

**Q34. Which card should be filed under IFC-IOR as the operational maritime-domain-awareness layer in an International Relations answer?**

A. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. B. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. C. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of IFC-IOR as the operational maritime-domain-awareness layer?**

A. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. B. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the

East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. C. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. D. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about IFC-IOR as the operational maritime-domain-awareness layer?**

A. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. B. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. C. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. D. The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they



treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q37. Which statement correctly identifies India's own naval and anti-piracy instruments?**

A. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. B. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. D. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.

**Answer: A. Explanation: Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



### Q38. Which card should be filed under India's own naval and anti-piracy instruments in an International Relations answer?

A. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. B. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. C. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. D. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.

**Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of India's own naval and anti-piracy instruments?

A. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. B. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. C. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime

engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. D. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about India's own naval and anti-piracy instruments?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. C. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. D. Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional**

maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The India-Maldives Joint Vision as the island-state instrument?**

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. B. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. C. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. D. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q42. Which card should be filed under The India-Maldives Joint Vision as the island-state instrument in an International Relations answer?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. C. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. D. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The India-Maldives Joint Vision as the island-state instrument?**

A. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. B. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an



advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. D. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The India-Maldives Joint Vision as the island-state instrument?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not



share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Colombo Security Conclave participation categories?**

A. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. B. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. C. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. D. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.

**Answer: A. Explanation:** At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q46. Which card should be filed under Colombo Security Conclave participation categories in an International Relations answer?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. C. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. D. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.

**Answer: B. Explanation:** At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Colombo Security Conclave participation categories?**

A. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. B. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. C. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. D. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy.

**Answer: C. Explanation: At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Colombo Security Conclave participation categories?**

A. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core

committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations.

**Answer: D. Explanation: At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q49. Which statement correctly identifies The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative and ASEAN centrality?**

A. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. B. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered



submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member.

**Answer: A. Explanation: India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q50. Which card should be filed under The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative and ASEAN centrality in an International Relations answer?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. C. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. D. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.



**Answer: B. Explanation:** India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative and ASEAN centrality?**

A. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. D. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.

**Answer: C. Explanation:** India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's

Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative and ASEAN centrality?**

A. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. D. India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.

**Answer: D. Explanation: India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider**

confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Exercise Malabar as interoperability evidence without obligation?**

A. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. B. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member.

**Answer: A. Explanation: Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q54. Which card should be filed under Exercise Malabar as interoperability evidence without obligation in an International Relations answer?**

A. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five

zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. B. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy.

**Answer: B. Explanation: Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Exercise Malabar as interoperability evidence without obligation?**

A. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. B. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. C. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance



commitment or a guaranteed operational response. D. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

#### **Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Exercise Malabar as interoperability evidence without obligation?**

A. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic



zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q57. Which statement correctly identifies AUKUS, the submarine pathway and the safeguards question?**

A. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. D. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.

**Answer: A. Explanation:** Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q58. Which card should be filed under AUKUS, the submarine pathway and the safeguards question in an International Relations answer?**

A. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. B. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. C. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. D. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy.

**Answer: B. Explanation:** Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's

acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of AUKUS, the submarine pathway and the safeguards question?**

A. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. B. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. C. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the

East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about AUKUS, the submarine pathway and the safeguards question?**

A. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. B. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. C. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval



Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Quad asymmetry as a structural limit on minilateral cooperation?**

A. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. B. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. C. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. D. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute.

**Answer: A. Explanation: Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather**



than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q62. Which card should be filed under Quad asymmetry as a structural limit on minilateral cooperation in an International Relations answer?**

A. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. B. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. C. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary**

**Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Quad asymmetry as a structural limit on minilateral cooperation?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. D. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Quad asymmetry as a structural limit on minilateral cooperation?**

A. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. C. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. D. Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Defence enablers and the simultaneous Russian capability base?**

A. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. B. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. C. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. The remaining options belong to different**



**Q66. Which card should be filed under Defence enablers and the simultaneous Russian capability base in an International Relations answer?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. C. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



**Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Defence enablers and the simultaneous Russian capability base?**

A. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. B. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. D. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Defence enablers and the simultaneous Russian capability base?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q69. Which statement correctly identifies The International Maritime Organization and India's Council seat?**

A. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework

was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. B. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. C. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: A. Explanation: The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (c) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

### **Q70. Which card should be filed under The International Maritime Organization and India's Council seat in an International Relations answer?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. C. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was**



elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The International Maritime Organization and India's Council seat?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. C. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: C. Explanation: The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (d) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**



**Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The International Maritime Organization and India's Council seat?**

A. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. B. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes.

**Answer: D. Explanation: The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (c) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q73. Which statement correctly identifies India as a user and defender of the treaty-based maritime order?**

A. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. B. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. C. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: A. Explanation: India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q74. Which card should be filed under India as a user and defender of the treaty-based maritime order in an International Relations answer?**

A. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. B. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: B. Explanation: India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of India as a user and defender of the treaty-based maritime order?**

A. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. B. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. C. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of

Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.

**Answer: C. Explanation:** India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

**Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about India as a user and defender of the treaty-based maritime order?**

A. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. B. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute.

**Answer: D. Explanation:** India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical



**Q77. Which statement correctly identifies External-power basing, island-state agency and honest question ownership?**

A. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. C. This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: A. Explanation:** Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.



**Q78. Which card should be filed under External-power basing, island-state agency and honest question ownership in an International Relations answer?**

A. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. B. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. D. Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.

**Answer: B. Explanation: Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of External-power basing, island-state agency and honest question ownership?**

A. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. B. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. C. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.

**Answer: C. Explanation: Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

**Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about External-power basing, island-state agency and honest question ownership?**

A. The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. B. MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. C. India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. D. Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Answer: D. Explanation: Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.**

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Four General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20 on Indo-United States and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words; 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20 on AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships, a Discuss the strength and impact demand of 15 marks and 250 words, for which the ledger records that the opening clause of the printed stem was truncated in the scan; 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 on the role of the International Maritime Organization in protecting the environment and maritime safety, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words with the word limit taken from the instruction block; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20 on the geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words. For the 2020, 2021 and 2023 demands the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership. Two objective demands are also routed to this owner and are carried as coverage requirements only: 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone, and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea. The official 2018-2023 Prelims keys are not held locally, and no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for either objective demand. Where a printed stem is recorded as truncated or defective in the scan, that defect is reported rather than silently repaired. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.

### OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

#### 9. PYQ application

- FACT: **2020 GS-II Quad cross-route:** "'Quadrilateral Security Dialogue

(QUAD)' is transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times - Discuss." Use this file for the maritime/ Indo-Pacific function, while topic 10 owns grouping classification and the correction that Quad is neither a treaty alliance nor a trade bloc.

- FACT: **2024 Q20 (direct):** \*Discuss the geopolitical and geostrategic

importance of Maldives for India with a focus on global trade and energy flows. Further also discuss how this relationship affects India's maritime security and regional stability amidst international competition?\* Structure: (1) Maldives' location astride key Indian Ocean sea lanes carrying trade and energy flows; (2) the India-Maldives Joint Vision (7 October 2024) as the concrete cooperation instrument; (3) SAGAR/MAHASAGAR and IORA/IONS/IFC-IOR as the doctrinal and institutional backdrop, noting India's IORA (2025-27) and IONS (from 20 February 2026) chairships; (4) external-power naval presence (Djibouti/Gwadar-type bases) as the "international competition" India must navigate without overstating its own "net security provider" role.

#### Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

**Status:** 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: \_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md.

- **Years represented:** 2024
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

| Year | Paper | Q  | PYQ demand (neutral rendering)                                 | Directive / format             | Source status          | Owner requirement                                                                           |
|------|-------|----|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2024 | GS-II | 20 | Geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India | Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words | Routed to owning topic | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |

#### What this owner must now support

- Geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

#### Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

**Status:** Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: \_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, \_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 5

| Year | Paper        | Q  | PYQ demand (neutral rendering)                                    | Directive / format                                     | Source status                                  | Owner requirement                                                                           |
|------|--------------|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020 | GS-II        | 20 | Indo-US and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability | Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words                         | Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |
| 2021 | GS-II        | 20 | AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships      | Discuss the strength and impact · 15 marks · 250 words | Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |
| 2022 | Prelims GS-I | 85 | UNCLOS territorial sea innocent passage and EEZ provisions        | Objective question; official key unavailable locally   | Routed; key unavailable locally                | Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.                   |
| 2022 | Prelims GS-I | 86 | Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute East China Sea       | Objective question; official key unavailable locally   | Routed; key unavailable locally                | Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.                   |
| 2023 | GS-II        | 20 | Role of the IMO in protecting environment and maritime safety     | Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words                         | Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |

#### What this owner must now support

- Indo-US and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability
- AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships
- UNCLOS territorial sea innocent passage and EEZ provisions
- Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute East China Sea
- Role of the IMO in protecting environment and maritime safety



The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

## 10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2020 Quad cross-route:** evaluate maritime-security cooperation and widening functional agendas, but route the alliance/trade-bloc taxonomy correction to topic 10.

- **FACT: 2024 Q20 (direct):** \*Discuss the geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India with a focus on global trade and energy flows. Further also discuss how this relationship affects India's maritime security and regional stability amidst international competition?\* An advanced answer should:

1. Ground Maldives' importance in specific sea-lane/chokepoint logic (Geography-owned detail applied diplomatically).
2. Cite the dated Vision document (7 October 2024) as the concrete instrument.
3. Name the external-power basing dynamic (Djibouti/Gwadar-type) explicitly as the "international competition" the question asks about.
4. Qualify any "net security provider" claim and note island-state agency as a genuine constraint on India's leverage.

## Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

**Status:** Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: \_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2020, 2021, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 3

| Year | Paper | Q  | PYQ demand (neutral rendering)                                    | Directive / format                                     | Source status                                                                | Owner requirement                                                                           |
|------|-------|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020 | GS-II | 20 | Indo-US and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability | Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words                         | Routed to owning topic                                                       | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |
| 2021 | GS-II | 20 | AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships      | Discuss the strength and impact · 15 marks · 250 words | Routed to owning topic; opening clause of the printed stem truncated in scan | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |
| 2023 | GS-II | 20 | Role of the IMO in protecting environment and maritime safety     | Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words                         | Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block          | Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion. |

## What this owner must now support

- Indo-US and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability
- AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships
- Role of the IMO in protecting environment and maritime safety

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

## PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 20

**Demand:** Indo-United States and Indo-Russian defence deals and Indo-Pacific stability, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership.

**Status:** Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

**Model solution:** Claim: simultaneous defence relationships with the United States and Russia contribute to Indo-Pacific stability only in a bounded and conditional sense, because they raise India's operational capability and interoperability without creating any obligation that would settle a regional crisis. Named evidence and example: the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange; Exercise Malabar, which expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, as the maritime interoperability route among all four Quadrilateral states; and, on the Russian side, Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract, which the owners record as evidence that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity. Analysis: the two tracks answer different needs, since the United States instruments raise the quality of shared maritime domain awareness and the reach of joint operation, while the Russian base sustains platforms and air defence that no other supplier currently substitutes, and their simultaneity is itself the demonstration of strategic autonomy that a single-supplier relationship could not produce; stability improves because deterrence and burden-sharing improve, and because a state able to operate with several partners is less easily coerced by any one of them. Qualification: the answer must not overstate the effect, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, competing supplier blocs and alliance perceptions can intensify regional mistrust, and the owners' own verdict is that defence deals contribute to stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. Why this earns marks: it discusses a causal mechanism rather than listing procurement headlines, prices each instrument at its exact legal character, and supplies the destabilising counter-reading that most answers omit.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 20", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

### Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

**Introduction and thesis:** Claim: simultaneous defence relationships with the United States and Russia contribute to Indo-Pacific stability only in a bounded and conditional sense, because they raise India's operational capability and interoperability without creating any obligation that would settle a regional crisis. Named evidence and example: the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange; Exercise Malabar, which expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, as the maritime interoperability route among all four Quadrilateral states; and, on the Russian side, Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract, which the owners record as evidence that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity. Analysis: the two tracks answer different needs, since the United States instruments raise the quality of shared maritime domain awareness and the reach of joint operation, while the Russian base sustains platforms and air defence that no other supplier currently substitutes, and their simultaneity is itself the demonstration of strategic autonomy that a single-supplier relationship could not produce; stability improves because deterrence and burden-sharing improve, and because a state able to operate with several partners is less easily coerced by any one of them. Qualification: the answer must not overstate the effect, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, competing supplier blocs and alliance perceptions can intensify regional mistrust, and the owners' own verdict is that defence deals contribute to stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. Why this earns marks: it discusses a causal mechanism rather than listing procurement headlines, prices each instrument at its exact legal character, and supplies the destabilising counter-reading that most answers omit.

## Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 20 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Claim: simultaneous defence relationships with the United States and Russia contribute to Indo-Pacific stability only in a bounded and conditional sense, because they raise India's operational capability and interoperability without creating any obligation that would settle a regional crisis. Named evidence and example: the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange; Exercise Malabar, which expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, as the maritime interoperability route among all four Quadrilateral states; and, on the Russian side, Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract, which the owners record as evidence that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity. Analysis: the two tracks answer different needs, since the United States instruments raise the quality of shared maritime domain awareness and the reach of joint operation, while the Russian base sustains platforms and air defence that no other supplier currently substitutes, and their simultaneity is itself the demonstration of strategic autonomy that a single-supplier relationship could not produce; stability improves because deterrence and burden-sharing improve, and because a state able to operate with several partners is less easily coerced by any one of them. Qualification: the answer must not overstate the effect, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, competing supplier blocs and alliance perceptions can intensify regional mistrust, and the owners' own verdict is that defence deals contribute to stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. Why this earns marks: it discusses a causal mechanism rather than listing procurement headlines, prices each instrument at its exact legal character, and supplies the destabilising counter-reading that most answers omit.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**How to improve this answer:** For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 20", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 20

**Demand:** AUKUS in the Indo-Pacific and existing regional partnerships, a Discuss the strength and impact demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. The ledger records that the opening clause of the printed stem was truncated in the scan, and that defect is reported here rather than repaired by invented wording.

**Status:** Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed, and no reconstruction of the truncated opening clause is attempted.

**Model solution:** Claim: the strength of AUKUS lies in long-horizon capability and technology integration rather than in immediate deployable force, and its impact on existing regional partnerships is to add an overlapping instrument to an already plural Indo-Pacific order rather than to replace any of them. Named evidence and example: the announcement of the enhanced trilateral security partnership on 15 September 2021 by Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States; the first initiative supporting Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines alongside an advanced-capabilities track covering cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisaging rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats; the settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022 following Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme; and India's own parallel, non-treaty route through the Quadrilateral grouping and Exercise Malabar. Analysis: the deterrence effect is real but deferred, because the pathway is a schedule conditioned on industrial capacity, approvals and sustained political commitment, so its present impact is felt through signalling, technology-sharing precedent and alliance management rather than through hulls at sea; the French settlement shows that a minilateral capability gain can impose diplomatic costs on other partners, and varied reactions within the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, ranging from arms-racing concern to more accommodating positions, show that the region reads the partnership plurally rather than as a single bloc choice. Qualification: the discussion must not treat Australia as having acquired a nuclear-weapons capability, since Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, and that negotiation proves neither a violation nor the complete removal of proliferation risk; nor may India or the Association be reduced to a binary pro- or anti-AUKUS position. Why this earns marks: it addresses both limbs of the directive with dated evidence, distinguishes announced schedule from delivered capability, and refuses two of the commonest overstatements in one qualification.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 20", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

### Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

**Introduction and thesis:** Claim: the strength of AUKUS lies in long-horizon capability and technology integration rather than in immediate deployable force, and its impact on existing regional partnerships is to add an overlapping instrument to an already plural Indo-Pacific order rather than to replace any of them. Named evidence and example: the announcement of the enhanced trilateral security partnership on 15 September 2021 by Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States; the first initiative supporting Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines alongside an advanced-capabilities track covering cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisaging rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats; the settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022 following Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme; and India's own parallel, non-treaty route through the Quadrilateral grouping and Exercise Malabar. Analysis: the deterrence effect is real but deferred, because the pathway is a schedule conditioned on industrial capacity, approvals and sustained political commitment, so its present impact is felt through signalling, technology-sharing precedent and alliance management rather than through hulls at sea; the French settlement shows that a minilateral capability gain can impose diplomatic costs on other partners, and varied reactions within the Association of Southeast Asian

Nations, ranging from arms-racing concern to more accommodating positions, show that the region reads the partnership plurally rather than as a single bloc choice. Qualification: the discussion must not treat Australia as having acquired a nuclear-weapons capability, since Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, and that negotiation proves neither a violation nor the complete removal of proliferation risk; nor may India or the Association be reduced to a binary pro- or anti-AUKUS position. Why this earns marks: it addresses both limbs of the directive with dated evidence, distinguishes announced schedule from delivered capability, and refuses two of the commonest overstatements in one qualification.

#### **Analytical body:**

**1. Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 20 **Analysis:**

Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Claim: the strength of AUKUS lies in long-horizon capability and technology integration rather than in immediate deployable force, and its impact on existing regional partnerships is to add an overlapping instrument to an already plural Indo-Pacific order rather than to replace any of them. Named evidence and example: the announcement of the enhanced trilateral security partnership on 15 September 2021 by Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States; the first initiative supporting Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines alongside an advanced-capabilities track covering cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisaging rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats; the settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022 following Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme; and India's own parallel, non-treaty route through the Quadrilateral grouping and Exercise Malabar. Analysis: the deterrence effect is real but deferred, because the pathway is a schedule conditioned on industrial capacity, approvals and sustained political commitment, so its present impact is felt through signalling, technology-sharing precedent and alliance management rather than through hulls at sea; the French settlement shows that a minilateral capability gain can impose diplomatic costs on other partners, and varied reactions within the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, ranging from arms-racing concern to more accommodating positions, show that the region reads the partnership plurally rather than as a single bloc choice. Qualification: the discussion must not treat Australia as having acquired a nuclear-weapons capability, since Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, and that negotiation proves neither a violation nor the complete removal of proliferation risk; nor may India or the Association be reduced to a binary pro- or anti-AUKUS position. Why this earns marks: it addresses both limbs of the directive with dated evidence, distinguishes announced schedule from delivered capability, and refuses two of the commonest overstatements in one qualification.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**How to improve this answer:** For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 20", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.



### PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 20

**Demand:** The role of the International Maritime Organization in protecting the environment and maritime safety, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger with the word limit taken from the instruction block.

**Status:** Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

**Model solution:** Claim: the Organization protects the environment and maritime safety by converting mobile, jurisdictionally awkward maritime risks into universally adopted technical rules, and its effectiveness is therefore bounded by implementation rather than by ambition. Named evidence and example: the Convention adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, establishing the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards with an Assembly of all members, a Council as executive organ and committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea governing safety of life at sea and the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships addressing ship-source pollution; the Ballast Water Management Convention in force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention in force on 26 June 2025; the reduction of the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020; and the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aiming at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints. Analysis: a universal technical standard works precisely because shipping is a single international industry in which a ship can change flag but cannot escape port-state and coastal-state inspection, so a rule adopted at the Organization reaches the whole fleet in a way no national regulation could; the sulphur limit demonstrates the mechanism, since one adopted figure altered fuel choice across a mobile global industry, while the ship-recycling and ballast-water instruments show the same method extended from air emissions to end-of-life and biological risk. Qualification: effectiveness depends on flag, port and coastal-state implementation, compliance and fuel-cost burdens vary across states and firms, and the climate limb remains contested, because the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and the talks were adjourned; India's election to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade gives rule-shaping access and no guarantee of preferred outcomes. Why this earns marks: it explains a regulatory mechanism instead of listing conventions, dates every instrument, and states the adoption failure honestly rather than implying a settled climate regime.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 20", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

#### Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

**Introduction and thesis:** Claim: the Organization protects the environment and maritime safety by converting mobile, jurisdictionally awkward maritime risks into universally adopted technical rules, and its effectiveness is therefore bounded by implementation rather than by ambition. Named evidence and example: the Convention adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, establishing the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards with an Assembly of all members, a Council as executive organ and committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea governing safety of life at sea and the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships addressing ship-source pollution; the Ballast Water Management Convention in force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention in force on 26 June 2025; the reduction of the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020; and the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aiming at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints. Analysis: a universal technical standard works precisely because shipping is a single international industry in which a ship can change flag but cannot escape port-state and coastal-state inspection, so a rule adopted at the Organization reaches the whole fleet in a way no national regulation could; the sulphur limit demonstrates the mechanism, since one adopted figure altered fuel choice across a mobile global industry, while the ship-recycling and ballast-water instruments show the same method extended from air emissions to end-of-life and biological risk. Qualification: effectiveness depends on flag, port and coastal-state implementation, compliance and fuel-cost burdens vary across

states and firms, and the climate limb remains contested, because the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and the talks were adjourned; India's election to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade gives rule-shaping access and no guarantee of preferred outcomes. Why this earns marks: it explains a regulatory mechanism instead of listing conventions, dates every instrument, and states the adoption failure honestly rather than implying a settled climate regime.

#### **Analytical body:**

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 20 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Claim: the Organization protects the environment and maritime safety by converting mobile, jurisdictionally awkward maritime risks into universally adopted technical rules, and its effectiveness is therefore bounded by implementation rather than by ambition. Named evidence and example: the Convention adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, establishing the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards with an Assembly of all members, a Council as executive organ and committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea governing safety of life at sea and the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships addressing ship-source pollution; the Ballast Water Management Convention in force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention in force on 26 June 2025; the reduction of the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020; and the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aiming at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints. Analysis: a universal technical standard works precisely because shipping is a single international industry in which a ship can change flag but cannot escape port-state and coastal-state inspection, so a rule adopted at the Organization reaches the whole fleet in a way no national regulation could; the sulphur limit demonstrates the mechanism, since one adopted figure altered fuel choice across a mobile global industry, while the ship-recycling and ballast-water instruments show the same method extended from air emissions to end-of-life and biological risk. Qualification: effectiveness depends on flag, port and coastal-state implementation, compliance and fuel-cost burdens vary across states and firms, and the climate limb remains contested, because the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and the talks were adjourned; India's election to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade gives rule-shaping access and no guarantee of preferred outcomes. Why this earns marks: it explains a regulatory mechanism instead of listing conventions, dates every instrument, and states the adoption failure honestly rather than implying a settled climate regime.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**How to improve this answer:** For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 20", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 20

**Demand:** Discuss the geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India with a focus on global trade and energy flows. Further also discuss how this relationship affects India's maritime security and regional stability amidst international competition. A Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger.

**Status:** Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

**Model solution:** Claim: Maldives matters to India because it sits astride the Indian Ocean sea lanes on which India's trade and energy flows depend, and the relationship affects maritime security and regional stability chiefly by testing whether India can hold an island partner's confidence in a space where other external powers are simultaneously present. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's record that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which establishes the sea-lane dependence the question asks about; the India-Maldives Joint Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership of 7 October 2024, with support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed on 25 July 2025 by free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit; the doctrinal frame of SAGAR of 12 March 2015 extended as MAHASAGAR on 12 March 2025; the institutional backdrop of the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025-27, the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium chaired by India from 20 February 2026 and the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region established in 2018 at Gurugram, which in November 2025 collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; and, as the international-competition dimension the question expressly demands, the ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar recorded as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the region. Analysis: the dated instrument sequence shows that India answered a period of political distance with more instruments rather than fewer, which is the operative test of whether accommodation survives partner-state political change; the institutional stack converts that bilateral trust into shared awareness, since a single island partnership is only as valuable as the regional information architecture into which it feeds; and the competitive backdrop explains why the relationship is priced strategically rather than commercially, because external basing is a structural, ongoing feature of the maritime commons and not a one-off event. Qualification: the answer must not overstate any limb, because the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty, the currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility and not evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference launch negotiations and do not conclude an agreement, chairships confer convening advantage and not control, and Maldives retains genuine agency to balance India against other partners for its own developmental and security calculus, so the net security provider label should be qualified rather than asserted. Why this earns marks: it answers both limbs of the printed demand, supplies the international-competition dimension the stem explicitly requires, and prices every instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 20", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

### Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

**Introduction and thesis:** Claim: Maldives matters to India because it sits astride the Indian Ocean sea lanes on which India's trade and energy flows depend, and the relationship affects maritime security and regional stability chiefly by testing whether India can hold an island partner's confidence in a space where other external powers are simultaneously present. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's record that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which establishes the sea-lane dependence the question asks about; the India-Maldives Joint Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership of 7 October 2024, with support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed on 25 July 2025 by free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit; the doctrinal frame of SAGAR of 12 March 2015 extended as MAHASAGAR on 12 March 2025; the institutional backdrop of the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025-27, the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium chaired by India from 20 February 2026 and the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region established in 2018 at Gurugram, which in November 2025 collaborated with twenty-five

partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; and, as the international-competition dimension the question expressly demands, the ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar recorded as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the region. **Analysis:** the dated instrument sequence shows that India answered a period of political distance with more instruments rather than fewer, which is the operative test of whether accommodation survives partner-state political change; the institutional stack converts that bilateral trust into shared awareness, since a single island partnership is only as valuable as the regional information architecture into which it feeds; and the competitive backdrop explains why the relationship is priced strategically rather than commercially, because external basing is a structural, ongoing feature of the maritime commons and not a one-off event. **Qualification:** the answer must not overstate any limb, because the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty, the currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility and not evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference launch negotiations and do not conclude an agreement, chairships confer convening advantage and not control, and Maldives retains genuine agency to balance India against other partners for its own developmental and security calculus, so the net security provider label should be qualified rather than asserted. **Why this earns marks:** it answers both limbs of the printed demand, supplies the international-competition dimension the stem explicitly requires, and prices every instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

#### **Analytical body:**

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 20 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Claim: Maldives matters to India because it sits astride the Indian Ocean sea lanes on which India's trade and energy flows depend, and the relationship affects maritime security and regional stability chiefly by testing whether India can hold an island partner's confidence in a space where other external powers are simultaneously present. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's record that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which establishes the sea-lane dependence the question asks about; the India-Maldives Joint Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership of 7 October 2024, with support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed on 25 July 2025 by free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit; the doctrinal frame of SAGAR of 12 March 2015 extended as MAHASAGAR on 12 March 2025; the institutional backdrop of the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025-27, the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium chaired by India from 20 February 2026 and the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region established in 2018 at Gurugram, which in November 2025 collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; and, as the international-competition dimension the question expressly demands, the ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar recorded as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the region. **Analysis:** the dated instrument sequence shows that India answered a period of political distance with more instruments rather than fewer, which is the operative test of whether accommodation survives partner-state political change; the institutional stack converts that bilateral trust into shared awareness, since a single island partnership is only as valuable as the regional information architecture into which it feeds; and the competitive backdrop explains why the relationship is priced strategically rather than commercially, because external basing is a structural, ongoing feature of the maritime commons and not a one-off event. **Qualification:** the answer must not overstate any limb, because the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty, the currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility and not

evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference launch negotiations and do not conclude an agreement, chairships confer convening advantage and not control, and Maldives retains genuine agency to balance India against other partners for its own developmental and security calculus, so the net security provider label should be qualified rather than asserted. Why this earns marks: it answers both limbs of the printed demand, supplies the international-competition dimension the stem explicitly requires, and prices every instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**How to improve this answer:** For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 20", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

**Question:** Explain why sea-lane and chokepoint dependence makes maritime security a first-order economic interest for India rather than a purely naval concern. Answer in about 150 words.

**Model thesis:** Dependence rather than ambition is the starting condition, so the answer must open with the Malacca transit share and the 26/11 maritime approach, convert that dependence into the domain-awareness and anti-piracy instruments that answer it, and close by conceding that awareness architecture manages rather than removes chokepoint vulnerability.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail.
- The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.
- Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here.
- Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024



General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Qualified conclusion:** Dependence rather than ambition is the starting condition, so the answer must open with the Malacca transit share and the 26/11 maritime approach, convert that dependence into the domain-awareness and anti-piracy instruments that answer it, and close by conceding that awareness architecture manages rather than removes chokepoint vulnerability.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain why sea-lane and chokepoint dependence makes maritime security a first-order economic...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

**Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** Dependence rather than ambition is the starting condition, so the answer must open with the Malacca transit share and the 26/11 maritime approach, convert that dependence into the domain-awareness and anti-piracy instruments that answer it, and close by conceding that awareness architecture manages rather than removes chokepoint vulnerability.

**Analytical body:**

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor records that more than half of India's trade traverses the Strait of Malacca, which converts sea-lane security from a naval preference into a first-order economic-security interest, and he links heightened Indian maritime-security consciousness explicitly to the 26/11 attack, when terrorists hijacked an Indian fishing vessel to approach Mumbai by sea; the examinable discipline is that the dependence claim is the starting condition of every answer on this topic, and that a single chokepoint dependency is a structural vulnerability rather than a manageable commercial detail. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor documents the Indian Navy's Far Eastern Naval Command at Port Blair and the biennial Milan naval-fleet gathering, which has run since 1995, as concrete instruments of regional maritime engagement, and he records India's active participation in the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia, abbreviated ReCAAP, as the multilateral anti-piracy channel, while Sagar Prahari Bal is a specialised Indian Navy force raised in 2009 for protecting naval bases and adjacent vulnerable areas and points; the owners route naval and anti-piracy operations themselves to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner and keep the diplomatic architecture here. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Dependence rather than ambition is the starting condition, so the answer must open with the Malacca transit share and the 26/11 maritime approach, convert that dependence into the domain-awareness and anti-piracy instruments that answer it, and close by conceding that awareness architecture manages rather than removes chokepoint vulnerability.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Explain why sea-lane and chokepoint dependence makes maritime security a first-order economic...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

**Question:** Comment on the proposition that chairing the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium has given India control over Indian Ocean security policy. Answer in about 150 words.

**Model thesis:** The proposition fails on the difference between convening authority and decision authority, so the comment must date both chairships precisely, name the consensus character of each body, and use the Information Fusion Centre's partner numbers as the evidence of what India can actually deliver without control.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic.
- The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026;

the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body, because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility.

- The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion.
- Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Qualified conclusion:** The proposition fails on the difference between convening authority and decision authority, so the comment must date both chairships precisely, name the consensus character of each body, and use the Information Fusion Centre's partner numbers as the evidence of what India can actually deliver without control.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Comment on the proposition that chairing the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Indian...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

#### **Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** The proposition fails on the difference between convening authority and decision authority, so the comment must date both chairships precisely, name the consensus character of each body, and use the Information Fusion Centre's partner numbers as the evidence of what India can actually deliver without control.

#### **Analytical body:**

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Indian Ocean Rim Association is a twenty-three-member regional intergovernmental organisation with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebène in Mauritius, and India assumed its chair in November 2025 for the 2025-27 term; the owners attach the limitation directly, because the Association is a consensus-based body in which a chairship confers agenda-setting and convening advantage rather than decision-making authority over members, and conflating the two is recorded as the single most common overstatement in answers on this topic. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Indian Ocean Naval Symposium was established in 2008 as a voluntary initiative to increase maritime cooperation among the navies of Indian Ocean littoral states, and India assumed its chair on 20 February 2026; the owners insist that the Symposium, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Information Fusion Centre are three distinct mechanisms rather than interchangeable names for one body,

because the Symposium is a naval-cooperation format, the Association is a regional intergovernmental organisation and the Centre is an information-sharing facility. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region is a regional maritime-security centre hosted by the Indian Navy, established in 2018 at Gurugram for maritime domain awareness and information-sharing, and as stated in November 2025 it collaborated with twenty-five partner countries and hosted International Liaison Officers from fifteen countries; the owners define maritime domain awareness as the capacity to detect, understand and respond to activity in maritime space affecting security, economy or environment, and they treat the Centre as the operational fusion layer of a graduated stack that runs from political forum through naval symposium to information fusion. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** The proposition fails on the difference between convening authority and decision authority, so the comment must date both chairships precisely, name the consensus character of each body, and use the Information Fusion Centre's partner numbers as the evidence of what India can actually deliver without control.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Comment on the proposition that chairing the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the Indian...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

### ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

**Question:** Examine the exact legal position India occupies in the treaty-based maritime order and state what that position does and does not permit. Answer in about 250 words.

**Model thesis:** Legal precision is the whole examination, so the answer must separate signature from ratification and ratification from party status, evidence India's use of Annex-VII arbitration and its 2016 statement at their exact levels, and name the concrete cost of the signature-ratification gap in the BBNJ Conference of the Parties.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here.
- The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation.
- India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute.
- The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes.

**Qualified conclusion:** Legal precision is the whole examination, so the answer must separate signature from ratification and ratification from party status, evidence India's use of Annex-VII arbitration and its 2016 statement at their exact levels, and name the concrete cost of the signature-ratification gap in the BBNJ Conference of the Parties.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the exact legal position India occupies in the treaty-based maritime order and state...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

**Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** Legal precision is the whole examination, so the answer must separate signature from ratification and ratification from party status, evidence India's use of Annex-VII arbitration and its 2016 statement at their exact levels, and name the concrete cost of the signature-ratification gap in the BBNJ Conference of the Parties.



## Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India signed the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on 10 December 1982 and ratified it on 29 June 1995, and domestically the Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976 defines India's maritime zones, while the Convention itself supplies the treaty framework governing territorial waters, exclusive economic zones and high-seas navigation rights that underpins all maritime-security diplomacy; the owners route treaty-law chronology and domestic legislative detail to the World History and Polity owners and keep only the application of that framework to India's regional engagement here. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The BBNJ Agreement, the implementing agreement on marine biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction also called the High Seas Treaty, was adopted on 19 June 2023, opened for signature on 20 September 2023 and entered into force on 17 January 2026 after the sixtieth ratification was deposited on 19 September 2025, while India signed it on 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification as of 3 August 2026; the owners require the status to be written as signatory and not party, and they name the concrete examinable cost, namely that a state which is not a party cannot vote at the Conference of the Parties that will design implementation. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** India's use of the treaty-based order is evidenced by two dated acts, namely its acceptance of the maritime-boundary award with Bangladesh delivered on 7 July 2014 by an Annex-VII tribunal administered by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, and its statement of 12 July 2016 on the South China Sea Annex-VII award calling for freedom of navigation and overflight, peaceful settlement, self-restraint and respect for the Convention; the owners fix the boundary of that statement precisely, because India called for those principles without pronouncing on the merits of the award, so an answer may cite the statement as evidence of India's rules-based position and may not convert it into an Indian verdict on the underlying dispute. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Legal precision is the whole examination, so the answer must separate signature from ratification and ratification from party status, evidence India's use of Annex-VII arbitration and its 2016 statement at their exact levels, and name the concrete cost of the signature-ratification gap in the BBNJ Conference of the Parties.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Examine the exact legal position India occupies in the treaty-based maritime order and state...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

**Question:** Examine the instruments through which India converts the SAGAR doctrine into island-state partnership, and state what those instruments do not establish. Answer in about 250 words.

**Model thesis:** Every instrument is real, dated and bounded, so the examination must move from the doctrinal statements of 2015 and 2025 through the Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 and the Conclave participation categories of 20 November 2025, and close by refusing to convert a vision document, an arranged facility or an observer seat into a guaranteed outcome.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.
- MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine.
- The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty.
- At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations.

**Qualified conclusion:** Every instrument is real, dated and bounded, so the examination must move from the doctrinal statements of 2015 and 2025 through the Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 and the Conclave participation categories of 20 November 2025, and close by refusing to convert a vision document, an arranged facility or an observer seat into a

guaranteed outcome.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the instruments through which India converts the SAGAR doctrine into island-state...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

**Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** Every instrument is real, dated and bounded, so the examination must move from the doctrinal statements of 2015 and 2025 through the Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 and the Conclave participation categories of 20 November 2025, and close by refusing to convert a vision document, an arranged facility or an observer seat into a guaranteed outcome.

**Analytical body:**

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** MAHASAGAR was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, stating that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the decisive precision the owners require is that the same speech reaffirms that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision, so MAHASAGAR is an extension of scope to the wider Global South and never a replacement of the earlier doctrine. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The India-Maldives Joint Vision titled India and Maldives: A Vision for Comprehensive Economic and Maritime Security Partnership is dated 7 October 2024 and is the anchor bilateral document translating the SAGAR doctrine into a specific island-state partnership, recording support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, followed by the signature of free trade agreement Terms of Reference with the launch of negotiations and an Indian rupee four thousand eight hundred and fifty crore Line of Credit on 25 July 2025; the owners qualify each item exactly, because a currency-swap arrangement is an arranged facility rather than evidence of drawdown, Terms of Reference are not a concluded agreement, and the Joint Vision is a bilateral political commitment rather than a self-executing treaty. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** At the National Security Adviser-level meeting held in New Delhi on 20 November 2025 the verified members of the Colombo Security Conclave were Bangladesh, India, Maldives, Mauritius and Sri Lanka, with Seychelles attending as an observer and Malaysia as a guest, and on 9 February 2026 India welcomed Seychelles' decision to become a full member without an officially recorded effective accession date; the owners treat this as precisely the case where the categories member, observer, guest and decided to join must never be collapsed into one claim, because each category carries a different set of rights and obligations. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency,

causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Every instrument is real, dated and bounded, so the examination must move from the doctrinal statements of 2015 and 2025 through the Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 and the Conclave participation categories of 20 November 2025, and close by refusing to convert a vision document, an arranged facility or an observer seat into a guaranteed outcome.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Examine the instruments through which India converts the SAGAR doctrine into island-state...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

**Question:** Assess whether minilateral and plurilateral maritime instruments can substitute for India's own maritime capacity in the Indo-Pacific. Answer in about 300 words.

**Model thesis:** Substitution is the wrong frame because every minilateral instrument in this space is non-treaty and asymmetric, so the assessment must price the Initiative, the exercise and the trilateral partnership at their exact evidentiary levels, use Tharoor's asymmetry finding as the structural limit, and conclude that supplementation rather than substitution is the defensible verdict.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement.
- Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response.
- Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022,

and India is not an AUKUS member.

- Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal.

**Qualified conclusion:** Substitution is the wrong frame because every minilateral instrument in this space is non-treaty and asymmetric, so the assessment must price the Initiative, the exercise and the trilateral partnership at their exact evidentiary levels, use Tharoor's asymmetry finding as the structural limit, and conclude that supplementation rather than substitution is the defensible verdict.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess whether minilateral and plurilateral maritime instruments can substitute for India's...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

#### **Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** Substitution is the wrong frame because every minilateral instrument in this space is non-treaty and asymmetric, so the assessment must price the Initiative, the exercise and the trilateral partnership at their exact evidentiary levels, use Tharoor's asymmetry finding as the structural limit, and conclude that supplementation rather than substitution is the defensible verdict.

#### **Analytical body:**

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India announced the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative at the fourteenth East Asia Summit in Bangkok on 4 November 2019 with seven pillars covering maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building and resource sharing, disaster-risk reduction and management, science, technology and academic cooperation, and trade, connectivity and maritime transport, and India's Indo-Pacific approach treats the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as the central regional architecture while describing the Initiative and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific as complementary, with the East Asia Summit serving as a leaders-led strategic forum and the ASEAN Regional Forum providing wider confidence-building; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that the Initiative is not a treaty, alliance or centralised funding body, that consensus and internal diversity can slow common ASEAN action, and that dialogue forums have weak enforcement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Exercise Malabar is the India-United States naval exercise that expanded to include Japan and, from 2020, regular Australian participation, and the owners treat it as interoperability evidence among all four states of the Quadrilateral grouping; the limitation is stated in the same breath, because an exercise creates no collective-defence obligation, so a candidate may cite Malabar to evidence practical naval convergence but may never convert participation in an exercise into an alliance commitment or a guaranteed operational response. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States announced the enhanced trilateral security partnership called AUKUS on 15 September 2021, whose first initiative supports Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines while an advanced-capabilities track covers cyber, artificial intelligence, quantum and additional undersea capabilities; the March 2023 pathway envisages rotational United Kingdom and United States submarine presence in Australia from as early as 2027, sale of Virginia-class submarines from the early 2030s subject to United States approval, and later Australian-built SSN-AUKUS boats, while Australia remains a non-nuclear-weapon state whose Article 14 safeguards arrangement with the International Atomic Energy Agency for naval nuclear propulsion was still under negotiation



in November 2025, Australia's cancellation of the French Naval Group submarine programme produced a settlement of five hundred and fifty-five million euro in June 2022, and India is not an AUKUS member. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor identifies a serious asymmetry in the relations among the various countries of the Quadrilateral configuration, observing that Washington enjoys long-established treaty relationships that other members including India do not share among themselves, so cooperation proceeds despite rather than because of symmetric alliance ties; the owners draw two consequences, namely that the grouping is a non-treaty coalition whose full institutional and membership profile is owned by topic 10, and that India cannot rely on it as a substitute for its own bilateral naval capacity-building through the Information Fusion Centre and Sagar Prahari Bal. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** Substitution is the wrong frame because every minilateral instrument in this space is non-treaty and asymmetric, so the assessment must price the Initiative, the exercise and the trilateral partnership at their exact evidentiary levels, use Tharoor's asymmetry finding as the structural limit, and conclude that supplementation rather than substitution is the defensible verdict.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Assess whether minilateral and plurilateral maritime instruments can substitute for India's...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

**Question:** Assess India's Indo-Pacific and Indian Ocean engagement as a single strategic design rather than a collection of unrelated maritime instruments. Answer in about 300 words.

**Model thesis:** The instruments cohere because each answers a different limb of one dependence problem, so the assessment must fix ownership first, evidence the legal, institutional and capability limbs with dated anchors, price external-power basing and island-state agency as genuine constraints, and close with a graded verdict rather than a claim of settled regional primacy.

**Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:**

- This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the

Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners.

- The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy.
- The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes.
- Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

**Qualified conclusion:** The instruments cohere because each answers a different limb of one dependence problem, so the assessment must fix ownership first, evidence the legal, institutional and capability limbs with dated anchors, price external-power basing and island-state agency as genuine constraints, and close with a graded verdict rather than a claim of settled regional primacy.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess India's Indo-Pacific and Indian Ocean engagement as a single strategic design rather...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

**Detailed examiner-grade model answer:**

**Introduction and thesis:** The instruments cohere because each answers a different limb of one dependence problem, so the assessment must fix ownership first, evidence the legal, institutional and capability limbs with dated anchors, price external-power basing and island-state agency as genuine constraints, and close with a graded verdict rather than a claim of settled regional primacy.

## Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns the Indo-Pacific concept, the SAGAR doctrine and its MAHASAGAR extension, sea-lane and chokepoint dependence, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea together with the BBNJ Agreement, maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief diplomacy and island-state partnership, and its distinctive feature is that it carries four verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2022; the physical geography of chokepoints belongs to the Geography owner, the institutional profile of the Quad belongs to topic 10, Maldives as a general neighbourhood relationship belongs to topic 02, the West Asian energy-flow linkage belongs to topic 06, naval and anti-piracy operations belong to the Internal Security maritime and coastal owner, the humanitarian relief cycle belongs to the Disaster Management owners, and treaty-law chronology with domestic legislative detail belongs to the World History and Polity owners. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The India-United States enabling agreements, namely the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, strengthen logistics, secure communications and geospatial exchange and combine with Exercise Malabar to provide a maritime interoperability route, while the India-Russia capability base of Su-30MKI and BrahMos cooperation together with the S-400 contract shows that Russia remains relevant to India's deterrence and air-defence capacity; the owners record both the gain and the cost, because interoperability is not alliance dependence or an Article 5 commitment, Russian-origin spares concentration and sanctions exposure can constrain readiness and procurement choice, and diversified capability strengthens Indo-Pacific stability only when combined with crisis communication, international law and non-alliance autonomy. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The International Maritime Organization Convention was adopted in 1948 and entered into force in 1958, and the Organization is the United Nations specialised agency for global shipping standards, with an Assembly including all members, a Council as executive organ and core committees covering maritime safety, marine environment protection, legal affairs, technical cooperation and facilitation; its instruments include the Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, the Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, the Ballast Water Management Convention which entered into force in 2017 and the Hong Kong ship-recycling Convention which entered into force on 26 June 2025, the global sulphur limit outside emission-control areas fell from three point five zero per cent to zero point five zero per cent mass by mass from 1 January 2020, the 2023 greenhouse-gas strategy aims at net-zero emissions from international shipping by or around 2050 with 2030 and 2040 checkpoints while the proposed Net-Zero Framework was approved at committee level but was not adopted in October 2025 and talks were adjourned, and India was elected to the Council in Category (b) for the 2026-27 biennium as a state with a major interest in international seaborne trade, which gives rule-shaping access rather than a guarantee of preferred outcomes. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** Value-added maritime-security material records ports and naval bases such as Djibouti and Gwadar as reflecting the growing military ambitions of external powers in the otherwise peaceful Indian Ocean region, which the owners treat as a structural and ongoing feature rather than a one-off event, while island states including Maldives, Seychelles, Mauritius and Sri Lanka retain genuine agency to balance India against other external partners for their own developmental and security calculus, the label net security provider is a strategic-studies commentary framing rather than settled official doctrine absent a specific dated official source, and disruption around the southern Red Sea and Bab-el-Mandeb can divert Asia-Europe shipping around the Cape of Good Hope, raising time, freight and insurance costs, although route disruption and complete closure are

different claims; on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2020 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 20, 2023 General Studies Paper II question 20 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 20, together with two objective demands, namely 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 85 on Convention provisions for the territorial sea, innocent passage and the exclusive economic zone and 2022 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 86 on the Senkaku Islands maritime territorial dispute in the East China Sea, for which the official keys are not held locally and no option or answer is recorded or inferred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

**Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

**Counter-position / limit:** A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

**Qualified conclusion:** The instruments cohere because each answers a different limb of one dependence problem, so the assessment must fix ownership first, evidence the legal, institutional and capability limbs with dated anchors, price external-power basing and island-state agency as genuine constraints, and close with a graded verdict rather than a claim of settled regional primacy.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

**Why this earns marks:** The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Assess India's Indo-Pacific and Indian Ocean engagement as a single strategic design rather...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.